

Aesthetic Transcendence: Tolstoy's Meaning Beyond Particularity

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Hadji Murat is a historical novel about the particular story of the real Chechen warrior whose name titles the novel. However, Tolstoy's aesthetic work makes such a story transcend its context. The dialogue between the prologue's thistle and Hadji Murat sets up a constant interaction of meaning, where the thistle makes Hadji Murat's death transcend its context. Aesthetics carries meaning where particulars fall short; spirituality, transcending particularity, is thus conveyed aesthetically rather than treated directly.

The spatial description of the initial scene sets up a dialogue between the particular and the general. Before entering the narrative following Hadji Murat, Tolstoy holds the reader in the prologue. It begins: "I was returning home through the fields. It was the very middle of summer. The meadows had been mowed, and they were just about to reap the rye" (Prologue). The initial pronoun "I" is vague: is it referring to Tolstoy? To a narrator? To Hadji Murat? Even more ambiguous is the "they" pronoun in the third sentence referring to the group of people who mow and reap. The space too is described without much precision; "home... fields... meadows", there is no precise location as there is at other points in the novel (e.g. "1851...cold November evening... Chechen aoul of Makheth" in chapter one). The notion of generality, as opposed to the particular place of action, is extended by the natural components "fields ... summer ... meadows" since these too create a geographical image that is not constrained. Nevertheless, lingering through this generality is a sense of fleetingness; the "very middle of summer" has no duration, it marks inevitable change, and the phrase "just about" points at another ephemeral

moment. The ambiguous pronouns alongside the fleeting particularity, set in motion a dynamic where the particular is capable of conveying the general, and vice versa.

As the aesthetics of the thistle elevate its meaning, a critique of humanity is carried through it. Observing a thistle, the narrator describes it as follows, “It was clear that the whole bush had been run over by a wheel, and afterwards had straightened up and therefore stood tilted, but stood all the same” (Prologue). Starting with “it was clear”, what follows would seem to only be incontestable claims about the trampled state of the plant. However, the phrase “but stood all the same” plunges into a more involved description. By drawing attention to the repeated word “stood”, the plant is subtly granted meaning. This is no longer a mere object in which standing is a mere state, the aesthetic interaction between the thistle and the narrator has made the plant’s survival one that communicates resilience. Now the plant is personified: “As if a piece of its flesh had been ripped away, its guts turned inside out, an arm torn off, an eye blinded” (Prologue). The verbs “ripped... turned... torn... blinded” describe the physical violence perpetrated against the plant. The aesthetic significance of the plant is manifested as it metaphorically becomes a live being: crushing a plant now has the weight of violence. Aesthetics gives life to the plant: “But [the thistle] still stands and does not surrender to man, who has annihilated all its brothers around it” (Prologue). The surrounding plants are now brothers; the standing thistle is a refusal to surrender. Humanified, the aesthetic lens of the wheel-crushed thistle has now elevated it to a conversation of resistance against mankind’s violence.

The story of the thistle makes it possible to see how aesthetic meaning transcends limits of particularity. While the thistle and Hadji Murat hint at one another throughout the story, their connection is felt strongly at the end:

But what had seemed to them a dead body suddenly stirred. First the bloodied, shaven head, without a papakha, rose, then the body, rose, and then, catching hold of a tree, [Hadji Murat] rose up entirely. (Ch. XXV)

The sudden stirring marks Hadji Murat's act as one pushing the limits of life: the scene is capturing the threshold between life and death. The next sentences slow down movement, pausing on each "first... then... then" with commas. The word "rose" is repeated thrice, culminating when Hadji Murat "rose up entirely"; this repetition of upward movement marks a certain elevation that tests death. Testing such limits, Hadji Murat "suddenly shuddered, staggered away from the tree, and, like a mowed-down thistle, fell full length on his face and no longer moved" (Ch. XXV). Marking a transition from movement to staticism, agency (as in self-control) is reduced to the point where Hadji Murat is now compared to a "mowed-down thistle", dehumanizing him as he dies while directly relating this moment to the prologue. However, such transition extends the meaning of Hadji Murat: where previously the thistle reflected mankind, now a man reflects a thistle. Hadji Murat's story is no longer restricted to its particularity and opens onto a broader discussion of life/death.

The aesthetic transcendence of particularity operates within the story itself. Tsar Nicholas's "cold, lifeless gaze" (Ch. XV) is mentioned repeatedly, texturing Nicholas' character as lacking humanity. Lifelessness is not the same as death; it is an aestheticized claim. A lifeless gaze construes an inhuman character which is clearly reflected in his hypocrisy in doing evil to Poles: "Nicholas regarded them as such (scoundrels) and hated them in proportion to the evil he had done them" (Ch. XV). While typically someone hates in proportion to the evil received, Nicholas hates in proportion to the evil he inflicts. His lifelessness is linked to his cruelty towards life; Nicholas says, "I'll destroy this revolutionary spirit, I'll tear it up by the roots" (Ch. XV). By antagonizing the revolutionary spirit, the lifeless character of Nicholas is contrasted with the revolutionary spirit. Moreover, when saying that he will "tear it up by the

roots”, Nicholas’ lifelessness is related to his active wish to attack life. Yet, it is not only Nicholas’ character that is lifeless, the aesthetic layer of his description also turns dry. Take the following scene, “After dismissing Bibikov, Nicholas, with a consciousness of duty well done, stretched, glanced at the clock, and went to dress for his coming out” (Ch. XV). The abundance of verbs “dismissing... stretched... glanced... went”, packed in short phrases produces a mechanical aesthetic where all there is are actions after one another. The verb “stretched” is given its own pause after Nicholas’ consciousness is described as one of “duty well done”: this generates a feeling of Nicholas comfortably following mechanical duties. The phrase “glanced at the clock” contributes to this sense of Nicholas reacting mechanically to the time, there is no space for agency. With no adjectives other than “well”, it is quite a banal scene. The lifelessness of Nicholas’ character is extended through the aesthetic layer: the content of the chapter is his cruel lifelessness, and the aesthetic of it conveys a feeling of banal mechanicality.

In contrast to Tsar Nicholas, Hadji Murat is humanized through his aesthetic interaction.

Facing a language barrier, Hadji Murat’s interaction with Poltoratsky is described:

Hadji Murat answered (Poltoratsky’s) smile with a smile, and that smile struck Poltoratsky by its childlike good nature. Poltoratsky had never expected this fearsome mountaineer to be like that. He had expected to see a gloomy, dry, alien man, and before him was a more simple man, who smiled such a kindly smile that he seemed not alien, but a long-familiar friend. (Ch. V)

The word “smile”, being repeated three times in the first sentence, draws attention to itself, culminating in the “childlike good nature” of Hadji Murat’s smile. The silence of such a moment of mutual observation is critical: without words, Poltoratsky is forced to reconcile his preconceived notions with what he is observing. The adjectives “fearsome...gloomy, dry, alien man” reduce Hadji Murat’s humanity: when interacting with someone gloomy and dry it is difficult to connect, thus they are alienated. However, when facing each other silently, Poltoratsky’s view of Hadji Murat overturns his previous notions: the familiarity he finds in

Hadji Murat closes the distance between the two. Through this aesthetic view of Hadji Murat, he is appreciated as a “long-familiar friend”: his simple, kindly appearance connects deeply with Poltoratsky. Aesthetically, Hadji Murat transcends individuality; he is anyone’s close friend.

Aesthetics as a means to transcend particularity, carries spiritual transcendence as well. Hadji Murat’s decapitated head is described: “Despite all the wounds to the head, the blue lips were formed into a kindly, childlike expression” (Ch. XXIV). In other words, despite death itself, Hadji Murat’s lips still convey innocent kindness. In an aesthetic sense, Hadji Murat has transcended life. In the retelling of his death, at one point he was struck in the neck: “after that he no longer felt anything, and his enemies trampled and hacked at what no longer had anything in common with him” (Ch. XXV). Hadji Murat’s body, that which was being “trampled and hacked”, was not “him” anymore; the subtle wording separates Hadji Murat (the body) from Hadji Murat. Aesthetically, such separation feels like a spiritual transcendence since the body is left behind but Hadji Murat persists. Returning to the parallel between Hadji Murat and the thistle, their aesthetic appreciation seems to transcend death. As the thistle “still stands”, just like Hadji Murat still expresses kindness, the plant is described: ““What energy!...Man has conquered everything, destroyed millions of plants, but this one still does not surrender” (Prologue). It is not as if the plant has gone unscathed; it is in terms of its aesthetic resilience that its energy persists. Energy becomes the word used to describe the transcendent meaning that lies beyond biological life or death. The childlike expression of Hadji Murat is such energy, its meaning transcends.

When one reads this historical novel it is easy to forget that this is a particular, real story: the aesthetic layer allows for the dynamics between a Russian Tsar, a Chechen rebel, troops, and generals to become a conversation between life, lifelessness, death, and beyond. What is on the surface a highly violent narrative becomes tender and human when aesthetics are considered.

The prologue relates the thistle to mankind, the story relates man to the thistle, and in their aesthetic interaction lies a spiritual transcendence where meaning is not confined by death.